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Fear is the most powerful enemy of reason . . . fear itself can quickly become a self-perpetuating and freewheeling force that drains the national will and weakens national character.

(Al Gore, 2007: 23-24)

Insecurity and national identity

Singapore's national identity has been strongly shaped by a crisis discourse centred on the struggle for survival and security. This discourse is geared towards reminding Singaporeans of the vulnerabilities associated with being a predominantly Chinese city-state surrounded by larger, densely populated, resource rich and potentially hostile Malay states. The acrimonious nature of Singapore's merger and separation from Malaysia, continued reliance on neighbouring countries for even the most basic of necessities such as water and food, experience of Indonesia's low-intensity Konfrontasi military campaign' and communal riots in the 1950s and 1960s, and persistence of regional ethno-nationalist sentiments have contributed to the PAP leadership's acute insecurity. These factors have, according to Deck, 'created a near paranoid cluster of communal security attitudes in Singapore' (Deck, 1999: 251). Driven by these insecurities, survival has become a 'one word political slogan' that has underpinned the PAP's reading of Singapore's many national challenges (Deck, 1999: 251; Chan, 1971: 48).

The survival discourse is particularly convenient for the authoritarian PAP government as it represents an effective means of rallying the masses behind a nationalist rhetoric that rationalises high levels of defence spending and compulsory military service. The unspoken but deep-seated fear of the more than 230 million Malays in the immediate region has been very effective in maintaining the culture of insecurity and shepherding the predominantly Chinese populace into line. In many respects, the security and sovereignty of the city-state have been subtly conflated with the continued political longevity of the authoritarian PAP government—implicit guardians of a Chinese dominated Singapore.

Consistent with the relatively large number of former military personnel in the

the SAF as the most technologically sophisticated military establishment in Southeast Asia. Official National Day parades are routinely spearheaded by a procession of military and security services personnel, followed by other national movements deemed integral to the city-state's national identity. In the 2007 National Day parade, the PAP fielded a marching contingent displaying party flags but the same right was not extended to opposition parties.' An army museum was opened in 2007 with the aim of documenting the development of the army since independence and visually narrating the stories of young men who have served their country by their participation in compulsory military service.' Not depicted in the narrative is the systematic exclusion of Malay men from military service and who continue to face institutionalised discrimination in the SAF.

Singapore, like other colonial settler societies, remains uneasy with the historical dispossession of indigenous land and insecure with the settler society's geographic distance from the 'mother country' (Burke, 2001: 261). In many of these societies, national identity is based on the representation of danger (Lawrence, 2006: 43) and a deep-seated distrust of neighbouring countries. The denial of indigenous traditional ownership of the land is supported by the reconstruction of a national history that reflects the triumphalist historical narrative of the colonial settler society. In keeping with this triumphalist narrative, Singapore's pre-colonial Malay history has been trivialised whilst the economic contributions of British colonialism and that of extra-regional immigrants have been celebrated.

The strategic culture of many colonial settler societies is strongly tinged by a tendency to 'perceive a threat where none exists, or, if one exists, to inflate its capacity to harm' (Rage, 2003:49). Believing that they cannot defend themselves against regional threats, a 'great and powerful' patron is relied upon to deter possible incursions of regional 'others'. In return for this protection, the military adventures of the patron and its global strategic interests are often uncritically supported (Cheeseman, 1999: 273). Driven by a fear of being swamped by the national and regional 'other', immigration policies have been tailored to preserve the numerical preponderance of the dominant immigrant community. Singapore's immigration policy of maintaining the numerical dominance of the Chinese community, the White Australia Policy and Israel's open-door policy to the Jewish diaspora are reflective of the deep-seated fear of losing numerical dominance and being engulfed by the 'other'.

Distrust and fear of the 'other' allows politicians to shore up their political base and rationalise controversial policies that reinforce the politics of fear. They recognise that when fear dominates, rational analysis is blurred and unpopular or controversial policies are more readily tolerated without critical examination. In this environment of fear, the ability of the majority to empathise with the concerns of the 'other' is diminished, leading to profound deafness and blindness to the genuine grievances of the latter (Ramadan, 2006: 12). To deflect public attention and maintain social control, peddlers of fear are inclined to promote negative stories about the domestic, regional and extra-regional 'other'. Thus isolated incidents related to the 'other' have been repeated and projected in the mainstream media as an alarming trend without serious analysis. Carmen Lawrence has observed how the

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civil service and PAP front bench and the persistence of compulsory military service, Singapore's national identity is strongly tied to maintaining the status of

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exploitation of inherently racist and irrational fears by the conservative Howard government led to a misdiagnosis of Australian national security — paradoxically channelling a disproportionate misdirection of resources to programmes and policies which have delivered minimal benefits to national security (Lawrence, 2006: 3). The 'war on terror' has also presented fear mongers with the opportunity to revitalise the discourse of threat and the politics of fear.

Not all colonial settler societies exhibit an insecure strategic culture and strong reliance on a 'great and powerful' patron to guarantee their national security. New Zealand and Canada have long adopted independent foreign and security policies, exemplified by their opposition to the invasion of Iraq in 2003. In Australia, the Keating and Rudd Labor governments made significant progress in strengthening socio-cultural and security ties with neighbouring Asia-Pacific countries. They recognise that deepening geopolitical and economic relations are reinforced by a deepening of socio-cultural ties. In coming to terms with the country's history of indigenous dispossession and discrimination, in 2008 the Australian and Canadian governments issued a national apology to the indigenous community. In an act of moral rectitude, courage and leadership, Prime Minister Kevin Rudd, on behalf of the Australian government, declared:

We apologise for the laws and policies of successive Parliaments and governments that have inflicted profound grief, suffering and loss on those our fellow Australians ... We take this first step by acknowledging the past and laying claim to a future . . . where we harness the determination of all Australians, indigenous and non-indigenous, to close the gap that lies between us in life expectancy, educational achievement and economic opportunity.⁴

This chapter highlights the significance of historical and socio-political factors in shaping Singapore's national identity, strategic culture and security policies. It examines the dangers of ethnocentrism in shaping security policies and producing negative and exaggerated perceptions of the national and regional 'other'. These perceptions have arguably contributed to a Singaporean national identity that is rooted in the culture of fear, paranoia and insecurity — a culture engendered and exploited by the authoritarian PAP government. This goes some way towards explaining why Singapore remains the only country in Southeast Asia to have compulsory military service, spends more than any other regional country in per capita terms on defence, uncritically supported the US in its invasion of Iraq, remains deeply embedded in the US security umbrella and suffers from a regional soft power deficit despite its myriad economic achievements.

Insecurity and the realist worldview of an authoritarian state

Insecurity remains the core theme of the realist school of international relations and

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security terms. Strongly framed within state-centric terms, realist notions of security are premised on the insecurity of other states (Burke, 2001: 240). As military strength is perceived as pivotal in determining a state's leverage in the international community, hard power becomes not only an instrument but an end in itself (Burke, 2001: 242). As international relations is thought of in anarchic terms and characterised by aggressive competition, states are expected to prepare for war and engage in regional balancing with great powers to guarantee their security (Emmerson, 2005: 4). The dominance of the realist worldview in Southeast Asia has meant that concepts such as regional human security and autonomous regional security remain highly problematic due to the focus on the engagement of great or big powers (Jayasuriya, 1994: 415).

It is also worth noting that the realist subordination of ethical considerations has meant that questions such as: is it right? is it just? is it in the interest of humankind? are deemed irrelevant. This ethical vacuum has allowed the PAP leadership to collude with notoriously corrupt and repressive regimes such as the Suharto New Order and Burmese SPDC regimes, particularly if bilateral relations are thought to benefit the economic and strategic interests of the Singaporean state. Indeed, the former long-serving Prime Minister and current Minister Mentor Lee Kuan Yew has acknowledged that he provided economic and geostrategic advice to Burma's Generals Ne Win, Khin Nyunt and Than Shwe (Lee, 2000: 361-362).

The Singapore leadership's propensity to maintain close economic relations with authoritarian governments irrespective of their political legitimacy and human rights record explains its defence of the pariah Burmese military regime in international forums. Thauang Htun, Representative for UN Affairs of Burma's government-in-exile, attributes the Singapore government's attempt to water down a UN General Assembly resolution castigating the military regime for its violent crackdown on pro-democracy activists in 1988 to its considerable business connections: 'Singapore is defending its investments at the diplomatic level, using its efforts at the UN level to promote its business links' (Kean and Bernstein, 1998: 334). Benefiting from being one of the first countries to resume relations with the Burmese military regime after its bloody crackdown which left thousands dead, detained and displaced, Singapore became Burma's largest trading partner and foreign investor in the 1990s. The non-government organisation Burma Campaign UK has listed 10 Singapore firms on its 'dirty list' of companies engaged in business with Burma.⁵

In the 1990s, more than half of Singapore's investments in Burma were purportedly in partnership with Burma's heroin boss Lo Hsing Han, head of the conglomerate Asia World (Kean and Bernstein, 1998: 331). The Singapore GIC chaired by Lee Kuan Yew has purportedly invested in the Myanmar Fund, controlled by none other than Lo and his son Steven Law.⁶ The GIC also co-invested with Asia World in the Traders and Shangri-La Hotels in Rangoon.⁷ Lo and his son have been able to set up businesses in Singapore despite Lo's record as a convicted drug trafficker. He was arrested in 1973, sentenced to death but pardoned by the Burmese military

is the main driver of Singapore's security policies. In keeping with this worldview, security is strongly understood in national rather than international or human



regime. Upon his release in 1980, Lo not only resumed his business activities in Burma but also served as advisor on ethnic affairs to General Khin Nyunt. This is

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unsurprising in view of the SPDC regime's reliance on the resources of drug barons such as Lo for its financial survival (Kean and Bernstein, 1998: 331).

Despite being denied a visa to the United States due to suspicions of drug trafficking, Law has been allowed to travel in and out of Singapore (Kean and Bernstein, 1998: 332). This is ironic in view of Singapore's reputation as the 'execution capital' of the world. The city-state's record for having the highest execution rate in the world is due in part to the government's tough stance on drug traffickers.¹ Paradoxically, convicted drug barons and their associates have been allowed to enter the city-state and set up businesses while small time drug couriers and addicts are mercilessly executed by hanging (Rahim, 2004: 16-17).

SPDC generals and Burmese drug barons have purportedly exploited Singapore's bank secrecy laws to engage in money laundering activities and used the city-state as a financial haven and a commercial window to the world. In the early 1990s, the Burmese military regime allegedly laundered US\$400 million through Singapore banks to purchase Chinese arms. Tay Za, currently the wealthiest man in Burma, has offices in Singapore.²

The PAP government's close economic tie with the SPDC military regime is matched by an equally intimate security relationship. The Singapore government has allegedly sold guns, rockets, armoured personnel carriers and grenade launchers to the military regime. The arms were supplied by Allied Ordinance, a subsidiary of Chartered Industries, which is an arm of the state conglomerate Singapore Technologies. Singaporean companies have also provided computers and communications equipment to Burma's defence ministry and army. Skilled in the science of surveillance, the Singapore government has trained hundreds of the SPDC's notorious secret police and about 5,000 SPDC officials through the Singapore Cooperation Program.³ It has provided equipment for the establishment of a cyber war centre geared towards monitoring dissident activity. Built with the assistance of Singapore Technologies, the cyber war centre is purportedly involved in monitoring and recording foreign and domestic telecommunications such as satellite telephone conversations of Burmese dissident groups.⁴

Realist technocracy

The realist foreign policy and security perspectives of the PAP leadership have been preserved by the omnipresence of Minister Mentor Lee Kuan Yew in Cabinet and the elevation of son Lee Hsien Loong to the Prime Ministership. Lee Hsien Loong served in the SAF for 13 years and attained the rank of Brigadier General and Chief of Staff when he retired from the military to run for public office in 1984, at the age of 32. Elected as an MP in the 1984 elections, he was promptly elevated to the position of Minister of State in the Ministry of Defence a year later. The following year, the 'meritorious' younger Lee was installed as a Minister for Trade and Industry, Deputy Prime Minister in 1990 and Prime Minister in 2004.

board, diplomatic and political positions and councils of higher learning. This process has been facilitated by programmes such as the dual-career scheme for SAF scholars which, from the early 1980s, allow President's and SAF scholars to be seconded to positions in the civil service or statutory boards. When retiring from the SAF, the scholars are also commonly appointed to senior positions in the public sector (Huxley, 1993: 7). This phenomenon has prompted Huxley to assert that by the early 1990s, Singapore's administrative state had evolved into a military administrative state (1993: 19). The career trajectory of the 'Mindef Mafia' (Deck, 1999: 253), which includes former Chief of Staff Brigadier General Tan Chin Tiong⁵ and Lee Kuan Yew's sons Brigadier Generals (Reservist) Lee Hsien Loong and Lee Hsien Yang, is indicative of the trend towards 'militarising' the bureaucracy, government-linked companies and the executive.

In step with their colleagues in the Ministries of Defence and Home Affairs, officials from the Ministry of Foreign Affairs are also steeped in the realist worldview of the PAP leadership. Understanding international relations as being driven by a state of perpetual tension or conflict between sovereign states, Singapore's first and long-serving Foreign Minister S. Rajaratnam is known to have subscribed to the adage, 'Each nation for itself' (Koh and Acharya, 2003: xvii). Former Foreign Minister S. Dhanabalan is on record for characterising international relations as resembling 'a Hobbesian state of nature, where each is pitted against all' (Koh and Acharya, 2003: xvii). Acknowledging that Singaporean diplomats are strongly imbued with realist notions of international relations, senior diplomat Tommy Koh lamented that they

have generally been indoctrinated by the theories of the realist school. They believe that the weight and influence of a country in the world are dependent upon a number of objective indices such as size of country, population, military and economy.

(Koh and Acharya, 2003: 237)

The realist worldview of Minister Mentor Lee, Prime Minister Lee and their military trained Cabinet colleagues have remained uncontested due in part to the technocratic orientation of most PAP Ministers. Many have been coopted into the PAP from the civil service without much political experience in the PAP or active engagement with civil society. In Singapore's authoritarian state, where opposition parties are weak and poorly represented in parliament, civil society emasculated and the public depoliticised, security related issues are 'taboo subjects in parliament and are often cloaked by a veil of secrecy' (Ganesan, 2001: 581). These issues are commonly perceived by the public as the preserve of the government and have generally gone unchallenged.

Jayasuriya (1994: 417) has attributed the lack of serious public debate on foreign and security policies to the unwillingness of Singapore based academics and policy institutes to directly challenge the PAP government. Research centres have been characterised as lacking genuine independence and unwilling to assume the role of intellectual agenda setters. Ideas for regional innovation are thought to primarily

The PAP leadership's realist worldview has also been preserved by the steady injection of active and reservist SAF officers into key administrative, statutory

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emanate from the bureaucracy or the Cabinet, leaving policy institutes in the role of 'cheer leaders for government policy ... [who] march to the beat of the state drum' (Jayasuriya, 1994: 417). Jayasuriya has accused them of 'being highly responsive to the interests of the Singaporean state' and functioning 'as an interlocutor for the Singaporean state's regional discourse' (1994: 417). In the same vein, Jones and Smith (2002: 100) assert that Singapore based security studies scholars are akin to 'scholar bureaucrats' who are aligned with the state and thus reluctant to speak truth to power.

Realist notions of sovereignty

The PAP leadership's realist worldview has encouraged it to aggressively confront neighbouring countries particularly when Singapore's sovereignty is thought to be at stake. This stance is fuelled by the barely concealed belief that the larger Malay-Muslim states of Indonesia to the south and Malaysia to the north have not fully accepted the predominantly Chinese city-state's sovereign status (Leifer, 2000: 2) and are envious of its economic success. The assumption is that without a formidable defence capability, Singapore would be at the mercy of her Malay neighbours. Reflecting this view, a senior official of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, Bilahari Kausikan observed that,

All too often, they focus on the fact that the majority of our population is Chinese and project upon us their own attitudes towards their Chinese populations. Sometimes our very success, our existence as a successful sovereign, independent, multiracial and meritocratic country is seen as a challenge to, or an implicit criticism of, other systems. Often the key issue is not what we do, it is what we are.⁶

Coloured by these views, even seemingly innocuous actions of Singapore's neighbours have been interpreted in a threatening light. Indicative of this realist paranoia, shortly after Singapore's separation, the PAP leadership described the republic in metaphoric terms as a 'valuable nut situated in a nut-cracker' (Singh, 1999: 275).

T.S. George contends that the PAP leadership's acute insecurity stems from the apparent willingness of some senior UMNO politicians during the tumultuous merger years to arrest Lee for acting against the national interest? This goes some way towards explaining the PAP government's request for the Malaysian security forces, located in Singapore since 1952, to vacate its barracks. In the ensuing tense bilateral exchange, the PAP government denied that Malaysia possessed the right to the bases in Singapore. Yet Article 5(3) of the Separation Agreement clearly states that

The Government of Singapore will afford the Government of Malaysia the

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use of these bases and facilities as the Government of Malaysia may consider necessary for the purpose of external defence.

(Chan, 1971: 38)

With separation in 1965, the Malaysian government had paid rental, revised in 1972 and 1974, for the location of its security forces in the Woodlands naval base. However, when the rental was revised from S\$1.9 million to S\$6.1 million per year in 1991, negotiations broke down after the Malaysian government accused its Singaporean counterpart of pressuring the Royal Malaysian Navy (RMN) to relocate despite Article 5 of the 1965 Separation Agreement recognising the RMN base in Woodlands (Singh, 1999: 200). The RMN finally relocated in 1997 to Tanjung Ponggelih in Johor amidst allegations by Prime Minister Mahathir Mohamad that the PAP government had repeatedly raised the rental to repossess the Woodlands naval base — indicative of its bad faith. Mahathir pronounced that the RMN had the right to stay **put** under the Separation Agreement." This point was reiterated to the author during an interview in Kuala Lumpur with Mahathir Mohamad in 2006.

The Singapore government has consistently advocated in international and regional forums that the violation of territorial sovereignty is an unacceptable conduct of international relations — a position rooted in the understanding that Singapore's sovereignty would not be guaranteed if such violations were condoned by the international community. Thus when Vietnam occupied Cambodia in 1979, ostensibly to oust the genocidal Khmer Rouge regime, Singapore led a vigorous ASEAN diplomatic campaign in the UN to condemn this occupation. The ethics of colluding with the genocidal Khmer Rouge in order to challenge the legitimacy of the Vietnamese backed Heng Samrin regime was secondary to the preoccupation with preserving the PAP leadership's realist notions of state sovereignty. Rationalising the PAP government's collusion with the Khmer Rouge, Singapore's former Foreign Minister S. Dhanabalan remarked,

The moral issue troubles many of us. But there were other issues at play. Who has the right to determine that a government or regime is evil and ought to be overthrown. The people of the country or some outside power? We held and still hold the view that it is the responsibility of a people to determine who and how they should be governed and that no foreign state has the right to determine what or which is a good government in another state.

(Dhanabalan, 2005: 42)

The idea that it is the responsibility of a terrorised and subjugated citizenry to be in a position to determine who and how they should be governed constitutes a major leap in logic. It is based on overlooking the Khmer Rouge's murderous record of systematically eliminating millions and depriving Cambodians of their basic

right to continue to maintain the bases and other facilities used by the military

political and civil rights.

forces within Singapore and will permit the Government of Malaysia to make _____

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Singapore and the regional security dilemma

The security dilemma in international relations literature commonly refers to states suspicious of the actions and policies of other states even though the intention of these states may in fact be benign. Suspicions can escalate into an arms race, or even war, particularly when states exhibit offensive postures by purchasing weapons with an offensive capability (Jervis, 1976) or shrouds its military equipment, organisation and capabilities in secrecy. This posture may be driven by the realist belief that the security of a state requires the insecurity of other states. In this environment, an arms race is often triggered off as states enhance their military capability to keep up with others believed to possess a more formidable military capability. In this classic security dilemma situation, states become more insecure despite their arms accumulation as the threatening image of other states becomes reinforced.¹⁶

Lee Kuan Yew has acknowledged in his memoirs that the rapid build-up of the SAF after separation in 1965 was strongly motivated by the fear of a Malaysian instigated coup against the city-state. Lee believed that there were senior elements within UMNO who deeply resented the PAP leadership and were capable of instigating military action against the city-state:

We had to deter and, if need be, prevent any wild move by the Malay ultras in Kuala Lumpur to instigate a coup by the Malaysian forces in Singapore and reverse the independence we had acquired ... If anything were to happen to Tunku Abdul Rahman, Tun Abdul Razak would become Prime Minister and he could be made to reverse the Tunku's decision by strong-minded ultra leaders ... The best deterrent to any Malaysian plan to regain control over Singapore was their knowledge that even if they could subdue our armed forces, they would have to keep down a whole people well trained in the use of arms and explosives ... other powerful Malay leaders, like Syed Ja'afar Albar who so strongly opposed separation that he resigned as secretary-general of UMNO, might persuade Brigadier Alsagoff it was his patriotic duty to reverse separation ... Keng Swee as defence minister worked feverishly to build-up some defence capability.

(2000: 22-27)

Indicative of the PAP leadership's acute Singapore's insecurity complex, a high five to six per cent of Singapore's GDP and 30 per cent of the total government expenditure is spent on defence — more than any other country in Southeast Asia.¹⁷ The city-state is one of the most militarised states in the world, with only Israel and Qatar spending more on defence in per capita terms.¹⁸ Singapore's status as one of the most densely defended states in the world (Huxley, 2000: xx) is compounded by the SAF's technological edge over its regional counterparts. The SAF's status as the most technologically sophisticated airforce in Southeast Asia is exemplified by the ability of its fighter aircraft to strike a target of up to 1,000 miles from a runway and its possession

Singapore's neighbours are no doubt also concerned by its technological edge in crucial areas such as armour, medium range artillery, combat aircraft and missile-equipped naval craft.

In many respects, Singapore's technological prowess is driven by the need to compensate for its lack of strategic depth. The SAF's reliance on conscripts and reservists is offset by their extended period of intensive compulsory military service and re-training (Huxley, 2000: 30). Compulsory national service ensures that up to 10 per cent of the Singaporean citizenry are directly associated with the military¹⁹ and provides the SAF with a highly skilled standing force of approximately 59,000 troops (da Cunha, 1999: 454) and 300,000 reservists²⁰ who are called up for brief periods of training each year. In a constant state of national military preparedness, fuel, water and food rationing exercises are periodically held, roads can be used as emergency runways, air-raid systems have been installed, food stockpiles maintained and a civilian bomb-shelter programme in place.

Notwithstanding the PAP government's projection of Singapore as the Switzerland of Southeast Asia, the republic's formidable military capability is closer to that of Israel. Both have surpassed their neighbours in terms of the volume of firepower, technical skill, level of unit operational readiness and technological advantage. Instructively, the commitment to maintain Singapore's military edge over her neighbours did not recede with the conclusion of the Cold War in the late 1980s. This can be attributed to the belief that the city-state's potential sources of military conflict Malaysia and to a lesser extent Indonesia — remained constant. If anything else, the cessation of the Cold War evoked greater insecurity as the primary rationale for a US military presence in East Asia had weakened (Singh, 1999: 283). In keeping with this enhanced insecurity, arms purchases from the US were stepped up.²¹

While other Southeast Asian states were pressured by the 1997 regional economic crisis to reduce their defence budgets, Singapore increased its defence spending significantly. In the financial year 1998-1999, and the following two years, its defence budget increased by 13 per cent (Huxley, 2000: 27). When other regional states had put on hold or cancelled their plans to modernise their military, Singapore took delivery of offensive F-16 fighters and 30 planes in 1998 (Collins, 2000: 104-105). Why the increased military expenditure at a time of regional demilitarisation and economic pressure? In addition to the deep-seated insecurity complex of the PAP leadership, Collins suggests that Singapore's enhanced militarisation was precipitated by a heightened sense of insecurity stemming from the unexpected ouster of the Suharto regime in 1998 and the rise of political Islam in Malaysia (2000: 105).

By 2000, regional militaries resumed their defence spending to pre-1998 levels,²² fuelled in part by the need to narrow Singapore's lead in sophisticated weaponry. Thailand purchased F-16s and Indonesia acquired Russian fighters.²³ Instructively, Malaysia, Thailand and Indonesia also expressed interest in acquiring diesel-electric submarines after Singapore acquired four refurbished Swedish diesel submarines in 2000 (da Cunha, 2001: 6). Raising the security concerns of neighbouring countries, Singapore's airforce superiority was strengthened further

of sophisticated air-borne radar systems for early warning (Leifer, 2000: 3).

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when it signed the US-led Joint Strike Fighter (JSF) development programme in February 2003,²⁴ rendering the republic the only Asian country to participate in the program. Regional security concerns were aroused by the establishment of a new air base in Changi which houses 20 of the RSAF's most technologically sophisticated jets such as the F-16, 13-52 and Fighting Falcon. These jets have enhanced capabilities like long-range fuel tanks, improved ground-mapping capabilities and an advanced targeting pod.²⁵ In 2005, 12 offensive F-15 fighters, which included advanced air-to-air missiles and satellite guided bombs, were purchased from the Americans. Particularly unsettling for neighbouring states was that these acquisitions provided Singapore with intermediate range anti-aircraft capability and ensured inter-operability with US forces in joint operations."

The SAF has since the mid-1980s moved from a 'poison shrimp' deterrence posture based on territorial defence to developing offensive oriented conventional capabilities. With these offensive capabilities, the SAF has the capacity to strike more than two hundred or more miles into enemy territory in coordinated ground-air operations with naval support for logistical systems (Deck, 1999: 250). This can be followed by the swift formation of beachheads in the adversary's territory (Deck, 1999: 250). This preemptive strike strategy is based on emasculating perceived aggressors in accordance with the logic that attack is the best form of deterrence. According to Deck, the strategic culture of the SAF and its preemptive strike strategy is premised on the questionable belief that 'equates fear with respect in subregional politics; they believe that the will and capacity to project power beyond their borders induces respectful fear in all potential adversaries' (Deck, 1999: 256). To augment this preemptive strike strategy, the SAF has apparently developed sufficient resilience to absorb the adversary's first strike (Huxley, 2000: 57).

The veil of secrecy surrounding details of the city-state's military acquisition, organisation and capabilities have undoubtedly fuelled the suspicions of neighbouring countries and escalated the security dilemma. It is difficult to ascertain the actual number of Singapore's combat aircraft as many of them are stationed overseas and thus not readily accounted for (Emmerson, 1996: 58). This secrecy is consistent with the tight control on information pertaining to security, defence and other issues. Reflecting this culture of secrecy, there is a dearth of detailed and coherent official information on the SAF released to the public (Huxley, 2000: xxi).

Since the 'war on terror', Singapore and other Southeast Asian states have steadily increased their defence allocations,²⁷ fuelling a 'slow-motion' arms race — whereby one country's arms acquisition precipitates other countries to acquire arms (da Cunha, 2001: 5). Southeast Asia's security tensions and arms race can also be attributed to the failure in resolving long-standing regional territorial disputes and economic competition between regional states. Unlike other regional blocs such as the EU, ASEAN has yet to establish a regional arms register that requires reporting of current weapons holdings and domestic production. As such, the exchange of defence information among ASEAN states has been minimal." The lack of exchange in regional defence information and ongoing expansion of military arsenals can be attributed to the long-standing bilateral tensions between

(da Cunha, 2001: 5). It is worth noting that Southeast Asia's regional arms race mirrors the broader East Asian arms build-up ostensibly fuelled by China and Japan's shift towards a more outward defence posture."

Suspicious neighbours: the Singapore—Malaysia security counter-balance

Tim Huxley has asserted that tensions between Singapore and Malaysia constitute one of '... the most sensitive and unstable relationships between any pair of ASEAN members' (Huxley, 2000: 45). One manifestation of the deep-seated tension between Singapore and Malaysia is their competitive arms build-up. As noted above, Singapore's military build-up in the post-separation period has been rationalised as a means of pre-empting a possible Malaysian military action, purportedly favoured by anti-PAP elements in UMNO who deeply resented the PAP leadership's political machinations during the merger years." Typifying the classic security dilemma, Malaysia's arms build-up has been fuelled by Singapore's aggressive preemptive strike option of invading neighbouring Johor in the event of a serious bilateral military conflict (Lee, 2000: 40). Beneath the semblance of military cooperation via defence agreements such as the Five Power Defence Agreement (FPDA), deep-seated suspicions persist. For example, during a joint-FPDA military exercise in 1970, the Malaysian government refused to allow Singapore tanks to cross the causeway (George, 1974: 171).

Unneighbourly suspicions have been fuelled by alleged SAF intrusions into Malaysian land and airspace. For example, in October 1987, the Malaysian government claimed that an SAF assault boat had intruded into a riverine area in Johor and accused the SAF of provocatively sending its soldiers into Malaysian territory on routine training exercises (Huxley, 2000: 45). Two years later, the Malaysian government detained nine spies accused of selling military secrets to Singapore. Instructively, this was not the first time that Malaysia had arrested spies allegedly working for the Singapore government (Huxley, 2000: 46). Rebuking Singapore for its alleged spying activity, Malaysia suspended all bilateral military exercises with Singapore in 1990. In the same year, Malaysia closed its airspace to aircraft from the Singapore Flying College and Singapore Flying Club following claims that they had conducted photographic reconnaissance over 'strategic' locations in Malaysia (Huxley, 2000: 46). It is worth noting that in early 1996, Australian intelligence officials alleged that Singaporean agents were engaged in covertly collecting intelligence on Australian military capabilities. Shortly after these embarrassing allegations, the RSAF's advanced flying training operation in Australia was relocated to France (Huxley, 2000: 200). The intrusions of Singaporean military aircraft into Malaysian airspace without authorisation have been perceived by Malaysian officials as a deliberate taunt by the Singaporean leadership emboldened by the belief that with US military facilities in Singapore, KL is not in a position to retaliate."

Yet in September 1998, Malaysia did retaliate days after Singapore attempted to terminate the Malaysian Customs, Immigration and Quarantine (CIQ) checkpoint

ASEAN states such as Thailand and Burma and Singapore and Malaysia

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in Tanjong Pagar by revoking permission for the RSAF to use its airspace in South Johor. To underscore its dissatisfaction with Singapore's handling of the CIQ issue, permission for the RSAF to conduct navigational training over airspace in West Malaysia, Sabah and Sarawak was also terminated (Nathan, 2002: 45). The annual Singapore–Malaysia Defence Forum, Semangat Bersatu joint army exercise and Malpura joint naval exercise were also called off in the late 1990s (Huxley, 2000: 213).

Emmerson has observed that the near doubling of Singapore's airforce between 1977 and 1984 had probably spurred Malaysia to rapidly expand its airforce (1996: 58). When Singapore purchased the AIN1-120C advanced medium-range air missiles in 2000,³² Malaysia purchased the Jemas air-defence system and Astros guided missile.³³ Shortly after Singapore's purchase of the Sea Serpent-class submarine, Malaysia acquired an attack submarine.³⁴ The SAF is ahead of the MAF in most aspects of military capability since the early 1990s and its military equipment procurement initiatives are geared towards maintaining this technological edge. The SAF countered Malaysia's comparative advantage in artillery by acquiring in 2001 US Apache attack helicopters that are effective against tanks, armoured infantry fighting vehicles and multiple-launch rocket systems. To counter Singapore's attempt to blunt Malaysia's artillery leverage, the latter announced its intention to procure several surface-to-air missile batteries in 2001.³⁵ Between 2002 and 2003, Malaysia spent billions of dollars modernising its military hardware with new fighter jets, helicopters, weapons systems and submarines.³⁶

Malaysia's arms acquisitions has in no small measure been shaped by the knowledge that in any military encounter with Singapore, the SAF is likely to adopt a preemptive strike strategy by utilising its superior air-power to capture part of Johor (Huxley, 2001: 208). The SAF's preemptive strike strategy is strongly shaped by Singapore's Second World War experience which clearly demonstrated that the narrow Straits of Johor does not serve as an effective barrier to an invading force from the north. From Johor, the adversary is able to cut off water supplies and shell the city-state which would be unable to effectively defend itself once the adversary had secured part of the island due in no small measure to its lack of strategic depth.

It is an open secret that Singapore's preemptive strike strategy has long been played out in SAF staff college simulation exercises. These exercises include devastating the Malaysian Air Force on the ground before mounting further air-strikes; SAF commandoes securing Johor Bahr and the second link bridge; amphibious landings to position the SAF's elite Twenty First Division on Johor's coast and seizing a zone approximately 80 km into Johor to secure Singapore's water pumping stations at Skudai and Kota Tinggi. However, the success of this military operation would require Indonesia to remain neutral — a less than certain presumption in a post-Suharto Indonesia where relations with Singapore have been problematic. A second front would be made possibly by Brunei or Thailand allowing the RSAF to use their airbases (Huxley, 2000: 59-63).

conflict. The SAF's strategy of pre-empting a potentially devastating first strike is strongly premised on the city-state's lack of strategic depth and need to preserve its water supplies in Johor. Thus, a minor dispute such as a Singaporean naval vessel firing warning shots at a Malaysian vessel in contested territorial waters could inadvertently trigger a serious crisis.

Even though Singapore's preemptive strike strategy is geared towards compelling neighbouring states to treat the city-state with circumspection (Huxley, 2000: 63), it may well have aggravated the arms race between Singapore and Malaysia and contributed to the militarisation of Johor — ironically making a military conflict between both states more probable. Malaysian military vigilance in Johor has also been fuelled by the claims of Johor's former Chief Minister, Mahyuddin Yassin Said that in the 1990s, Lee Kuan Yew threatened war with Malaysia if the city-state's water supply from Johor was cut off.³⁷ Reiterating these concerns, retired Malaysian Army General Zaini Mohamed has suggested that an escalating water dispute could well lead to military conflict due in no small part to Singapore's offensive preemptive strike strategy.³⁸ Demonstrating that KL has not taken Singapore's preemptive strike policy lightly, Johor's defences have been buttressed by the building of two large military bases from the late 1990s and a commando training camp built near Mersing in 2001 (da Cunha, 2001: 14).

The racialised security apparatus

It is an open secret that Singapore Malays have been excluded from full integration into the structure of the SAF. The exclusion of Malays from 'compulsory' national service for much of the 1960s, 1970s and 1980s and continued discrimination in the SAF despite the official rhetoric of the socially integrative nature of national service, can be attributed to the perception that Malaysia and to a lesser extent Indonesia are Singapore's most likely military adversaries. To be sure, the ethno-nationalist strategic culture³⁹ of the PAP leadership has not escaped political elites from Malaysia and Indonesia.

Determined to overturn the dominance of Malays in the military forces after separation from Malaysia, recruitment of Malays into the SAF was virtually halted after 1967, even though Malays made up 80 per cent of volunteers in the armed services. Malay officers and non-commissioned officers were systematically transferred from field command to logistics and support sections while others were retired or shut off from promotion (Huxley, 2000: 102-103). Walsh has observed that the PAP leadership's distrust and fear of Malays led it to 'sacrifice virtually, all the experience and professionalism that had been built up before 1965 in exchange for a Chinese dominated military' (2007: 273). The paranoid distrust of Malays is demonstrated by the reliance of the SAF's intelligence services on ethnic Chinese proficient in Malay, rather than Malay personnel, to analyse Malay newspapers (Walsh, 2007: 273).

Since independence, Malay participation in sensitive areas in the SAF such as armoury and tank units, front-line combat infantry and the airforce have been restricted (Mutalib, 2002: 43). Continued discrimination of Malays in the more

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A major flaw with Singapore's preemptive strike strategy is that a relatively minor dispute with Malaysia could potentially escalate into a full blown military

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'sensitive' wings of the SAF such as the air force was rationalised by Lee Kuan Yew in 1999 in the following way:

If for instance you put a Malay officer who's very religious and who has family ties in Malaysia in charge of a machine gun unit, that is a very tricky business . . . If today the Prime Minister doesn't think about this, we could have tragedy."

Driven by this paranoid geostrategic mindset, the first Malay air-force pilot was only appointed in 1992 and the first Malay fighter pilot in 2003.⁴¹

Reminding Singaporeans of the potential security risk posed by Malays, Lee has stated that our concerns about conflicting realities are real. We know of at least one case where foreign intelligence agencies approached one of our senior officers because he was Malay.⁴² The geostrategic calculation underpinning this paranoid outlook was evident by Lee's assertion that

If there's an enormous disturbance in Malaysia, we are going to be affected. If there's an enormous disturbance in Indonesia, especially in Batam, the Riau Islands, we are going to be affected. It's a fact of life. We have to face the real world and the real world is unfair and unkind. It cannot be helped.⁴³

In regional terms, the PAP government's long-standing policy of restricting opportunities for Malays in the SAF has had the effect of signalling to the city-state's Malay neighbours that they remain the most serious military threat to its sovereignty — hardly the recipe for nurturing regional goodwill. The SAF's discriminatory policy serves to reinforce regional suspicions that the PAP leadership has nurtured a society that suffers from a siege mentality and is 'out of place' in the Malay World. Not surprisingly, these discriminatory policies have engendered Malay resentment and alienation with their second class status in a supposedly meritocratic society. They have also engendered the public perception that Malay loyalty to the country is suspect, thereby fuelling latent inter-ethnic tensions. Without doubt, the perception of dubious Malay loyalty to the country has been reinforced by the alleged discovery of a militant .11 network in Singapore.

To be sure, compulsory military service was introduced in part from the awareness that the Chinese are traditionally disdainful of military service.⁴⁴ Without compulsory military service, the Singapore government would have faced major challenges in building a sizeable reserve army, leaving it reliant on a predominantly Malay military force (Walsh, 2007: 275). Why then have Malays traditionally identified with and participated in the military establishment? Jeshurun purports that Malays have, from the era of pre-colonial Malay kingdoms, accorded high status to human qualities such as bravery and the willingness to fight and die in defence of their land. This is demonstrated by the strong collective memory of the Royal Malay Regiment (RMR) who selflessly fought the Japanese in the Battle of Singapore in February 1942 (Jeshurun, 1999: 233). The RMR's fierce resistance

The SAF's system of training and promotion based on the rapid elevation of the predominantly Chinese SAF scholar officers⁴⁵ may have undermined the structural foundations and efficacy of the SAF in combat. Scholar officers make up a disproportionately higher percentage of senior officers, reaching the rank of major, lieutenant colonel or full colonel in only eight years. This process of fast-tracking, uncommon in other military establishments, has allowed operationally inexperienced scholar officers to be promoted ahead of the more experienced non-graduate regular officers (Walsh, 2007: 269-270). Yet Singapore's senior military officers are also one of the most highly paid military officers in the world despite their lack of operational experience (da Cunha, 1999: 457). The fast-tracking of operationally inexperienced scholar officers has prompted Walsh to question the ability of such senior officers to lead in a conflict against battle-hardened troops (2007: 268).

In geostrategic terms, there is a strong case to be made for terminating discriminatory policies against Malays in the SAF and promoting an ethnically representative military at the senior officer level. Stronger Malay representation, particularly at the senior levels, could assist in tempering regional perceptions that the discriminatory practices against Malays in the SAF is reflective of a Chinese dominated city-state that is distrustful of its neighbours. Regional resentment against the PAP government's discriminatory policies was clearly highlighted in 1999 when Indonesian President B.J. Habibie accused the Singapore government of being racist, pointing to its discriminatory policies against Malays in the SAF. A substantial number of senior Malay officers would help promote cross-cultural sensitivity within the predominantly Chinese SAF senior officer corps (Walsh, 2007: 276). An ethnically diverse SAF officer corp could well strengthen domestic security needs and assist in the efficacy of Singapore's regional peacekeeping and humanitarian operations (Walsh, 2007: 273). In many respects, the full integration of Malays into the SAF constitutes a barometer of Singapore's genuine regional integration and status as a genuinely meritocratic and multiracial society.

Siege mentality states in collusion

Singapore suffers from the reputation of being the Israel of Southeast Asia. Both are strongly driven by a fear and distrust of the national and regional 'other'. Engulfed by this siege mentality, both states have relied on the US as their 'great and powerful' patron, built up a military arsenal that is second to none in the region and institutionalised a total defence strategy" which discriminates against full Muslim participation in the military. Lacking in strategic depth due to their limited size, their military establishment is offensive in orientation and geared towards a preemptive strike against those assuming 'threatening proportions'. This strategy is based on waging war in enemy territory.

Like Israel, Singapore's settler society has not strongly identified, in socio-cultural terms, with the immediate region. Just as Israel is more strongly culturally enmeshed with Europe and the Western world, Singaporeans have been strongly encouraged to identify, in cultural terms, with Northeast Asians. Notwithstanding the realities of geography, these colonial settler societies do not see themselves as

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against the Japanese has become folklore in Malaysia, but instructively is less well known in Singapore.

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part of the region and exhibit an 'in the region but not of the region' mentality. Sharing similar worldviews and security concerns, the colonial settler societies of Singapore and Israel are not surprisingly 'natural allies' embedded in the US security umbrella.

While Singapore's very close relationship with the US may have caused some unease in KL and Jakarta, her close ties with Israel has generated considerable resentment particularly amongst Muslims in the region. Like Israel, Singapore's technological and industrial sophistication, formidable military capacity and close ties with the United States have enabled it to assume a status beyond its restricted land area and population base. This status is underpinned by Israel's proven and Singapore's potential ability to inflict damage out of proportion to its size in a military conflict with neighbours.

Singapore's close relations with Israel can be profitably understood within the context of Singapore's post-separation attempts to build a defence establishment. In particular, when India, Egypt and Switzerland declined Singapore's request for assistance to build up its fledgling armed forces, Israel was forthcoming. This must have greatly pleased Lee Kuan Yew and Defence Minister Goh Keng Swee who were most impressed by Israel's ability to overpower her larger Muslim neighbours in several wars. The parallel threat perceptions of both colonial settler societies has been acknowledged by former PAP Minister Othman Wok in the following way: 'Israel was not a big country and was surrounded by hostile neighbours. We were in a similar position' (2000: 205).

By the end of 1965, an Israeli military delegation headed by General Ya'akov Elazari arrived in Singapore to model the SAF on the Israeli Defence Force.⁴⁷ Just as Israeli military advisers and their families based in Singapore posed as Mexicans, Singaporean officials visiting Israel assumed a fictitious identity.⁴⁸ Not surprisingly, Israel's role in building up Singapore's military establishment aroused regional suspicions. For example, in a meeting with Lee Kuan Yew in the early 1970s, Indonesian General Sumitro, Commander of the Internal Security Department, had apparently asked why the Singapore government had engaged Israeli military advisers and instructors. Recounting this meeting, Singapore's former ambassador to Indonesia wrote, 'He (Sumitro) feared that Singapore would develop similar policies to Israel's in Southeast Asia' (Lee Khoo Choy, 2005: 80).

In line with the Israeli security model, the SAF has been transformed from a small force of regulars and volunteer reservists into a citizen force based on compulsory national conscription and reservist service (Huxley, 2000: 11). Selected senior military personnel have apparently been sent to Israel for training. Reminiscent of Israel's policy of excluding Palestinians from 'compulsory' conscription, Singaporean Muslims were excluded from 'compulsory' military service for more than a decade. The Israeli stamp on the broader Singaporean polity was demonstrated by the appointment of Israeli advisers in the formative years of the National Trade Union Congress and the National Youth Training Institute.⁴⁹

Indicative of their close strategic cooperation, most of Israel's arms sales to Singapore are in the form of joint military ventures with Singapore financing

purchased Israeli anti-tank and anti-aircraft missiles and until a few years ago, Singapore was the Israeli defence industry's largest customer" of arms and weapons systems.⁵⁰ Both countries have cooperated in the development and manufacture of military hardware such as the Spike anti-tank missile." They have jointly developed surveillance and intelligence gathering satellites, with Israel providing the technology and Singapore the funds. Inter alia, this project will enable Singapore to develop its own space programme." Following the Israeli military model, Singapore has fused commercial and strategic concerns, with the setting up of Chartered Industries in 1967 and subsequent evolution into Singapore Technologies (Kwok, 1999: 58). Israel's and Singapore's cutting-edge arms industries have enabled both countries to maintain their military superiority over Muslim neighbours.

Regional apprehensions towards Singapore's intimate ties with Israel were evident when the Singapore government invited Israeli President Chaim Herzog to the republic in 1986. Weeks before the arrival of Herzog, Muslim organisations mobilised against the visit. Despite Malaysia, Indonesia and Brunei's deliberate refusal to establish diplomatic ties with Israel, Herzog's visit to Singapore, without prior consultation with neighbouring countries, revealed the PAP leadership's lack of diplomatic sensitivity. Regional tensions were aggravated further when the Filipino government, in a gesture of regional sensitivity, hastily cancelled Herzog's visit to the Philippines (Nair, 1997: 229). When it was clear that the PAP government was intent on following through with Herzog's visit despite regional pressure, Malaysia, Indonesia and Brunei registered their protest by recalling their heads of mission from the city-state during Herzog's visit to Singapore in November 1986. Angered by the visit, Singapore was denounced as a 'second Israel' in the Malaysian Malay language dailies (Nair, 1997: 227). The virulent regional protests constituted the lowest point in Singapore's relations with her neighbours since 1965 (Singh, 1999: 214). These protests were fuelled by regional perceptions that the Singaporean leadership valued its diplomatic relations and extensive military links with Israel over her neighbours. Reiterating these concerns, Malaysia's Deputy Defence Minister Abdullah Fadzil Che Wan in 1999 urged the Singapore government to be more sensitive to Malaysia's concerns about its military cooperation with Israel (Andrew Tan, 2004: 51).

Relations with Israelis have shaped the city-state's foreign policy orientation on Palestinian self-determination and the Middle East in general. Lee Kuan Yew has frankly acknowledged that when the 1967 Arab—Israeli war broke out, Singapore was keen to appease Israel.

... we were relieved the Israelis were not defeated or our SAF would have lost confidence in their Israeli instructors. When the UN General Assembly was debating the resolution to condemn Israel ... Keng Swee saw me to press Raja to direct our UN delegate not to vote in favour of the resolution or the Israeli's would leave ... We had to stand up for the right of small nations to exist ... We abstained, and the Israelis did not leave.

(Lee, 2000: 43)

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much of Israel's research and development and arms exports to it. Singapore has

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